Westbrook City Council

~ Committee of the Whole ~

Date: Monday, October 5, 2026

Time: ~7:00 PM (immediately following the Regular City Council meeting — approximate, per the agenda)

Location: Westbrook High School (Room 114), 125 Stroudwater St. (Hybrid via Zoom)

Video: https://vimeo.com/1233192505

Packet: https://www.westbrookmaine.gov/AgendaCenter/ViewFile/Agenda/_10052026-1033

Timestamps below are clickable [0:00]-style links — they jump straight to that moment in the video.

This summary highlights the meeting's key discussions and decisions, with direct quotes and timestamps for verification — it is not a substitute for watching the full meeting. *Summarization necessarily condenses and selects; for complete context, nuance, and anything not covered here, watch the full video at the link above. (Produced by: WestbrookCurrents.com)*

I. Roll Call

Roll Call & Opening Remarks [03:34]

Discussion Summary

Chair Gary Rairdon opened the meeting, noting this was one of the last in a series of Committee of the Whole reviews of city board/committee ordinances, and asked for civility given how passionate this particular topic tends to be. Roll call: Councilors McCambridge, Shaughnessy (Vice President), Munro (President), Chau, and Faulkingham, plus Chair Rairdon, answered present — six of seven members. Councilor Anna Turcotte was not named at roll call.

Key Decisions

✓ **Quorum established.**

Action Items

None.

Recreation & Conservation Commission Ordinance Review

[05:15] City Administrator Angela Holmes presented a repeal-and-replace of Code of Ordinances Chapter 7, Article III (Recreation & Conservation Commission), plus related amendments to Chapter 295 (Trees, Green Space) — the same rewrite that later passed as Order 2026-116 at the Oct 19, 2026 Special City Council Meeting. This is the Committee of the Whole's review and referral step; no commission members were present or spoke tonight despite two invitations from the Chair.

Staff's rationale (City Administrator Angela Holmes)

The 1970 ordinance (amended 1987, 2018) carried over 1960s state-statute language that assigns operational (department), executive (mayoral), and legislative (council) authority to what is legally only an advisory body — conflicting with the City Charter. Staff met with the Commission four separate times, including a paused first attempt after initial pushback, before drafting this version; that feedback is included in the packet. The

Commission currently has up to 10 seats (7 regular + 3 alternate); 7 regular and 1 of 3 alternate seats are filled.

Cited charter conflicts include the Commission's current authority to "plan, develop, and conserve open areas," direct city-forest management, compel other departments to assist it, acquire land "subject to council approval" (the Charter reserves land acquisition solely to the Council), coordinate other conservation bodies, initiate environmental studies (implying control over department priorities), and solicit grants/gifts (bypassing the Council's appropriation process and the Mayor's veto). Staff emphasized preserving the Commission's real track record: the Green Space ordinance (350 designated acres), partnerships with the Presumpscot Regional Land Trust (PRLT) and Portland Trails, subdivision-application review, and open-space-fund recommendations (two went to Council earlier that same evening).

Staff's draft renames the body "Parks and Recreation Committee," drops the state-statute reference, keeps 7 members while eliminating the 3 alternate seats, drops the citizenship requirement (keeping Westbrook residency), adds a purpose statement, removes the ban on member compensation, matches the Planning Board's removal process (mayoral complaint + 2/3 Council vote), drops the Secretary role and annual-report obligation, requires quarterly meetings called by the City Planner and/or Sustainability Coordinator, and — at the Commission's own request — strikes its old supervisory-sounding language over city arborists. Transferring a Green Space parcel to a certified land trust (PRLT) would automatically remove its Green Space designation.

Floor Amendments — Vice President Michael Shaughnessy (a former Commission member)

> *"I would move that it gets changed to Recreation and Sustainability Committee. Reason being is that there's the sustainability director [that] is part of it, it seems to make sense… sustainability seems to be very much overlapped with what conservation is all about. I mean they're indistinguishable from each other."*

— Vice President Michael Shaughnessy [45:50]

Shaughnessy, developing the language with staff in advance (staff stated they fully support it), proposed renaming the body **"Recreation and Sustainability Committee"** instead of staff's draft "Parks and Recreation Committee," expanding the purpose statement for clarity, and giving the Chair and Vice Chair an explicit role facilitating meetings. He separately raised — as an operational commitment rather than ordinance text — a one-year report-back once the new committee is established; this became the formal amendment attached when the full ordinance passed Oct 19.

Key Decisions

✓ Shaughnessy's three floor amendments (name, purpose statement, Chair/Vice Chair meeting role), combined into one motion, approved 6–0 by roll call [50:18] **(McCambridge, Shaughnessy, Munro, Chau, Faulkingham, Rairdon).**

Commission Member & Public Comment

No Recreation & Conservation Commission members were present or identified on Zoom despite two invitations to speak. One resident spoke:

> *"Someone has got to be a resident to be on this commission. Does that mean they must be a U.S. citizen or a legal resident?"*

— Ken Boston, Westbrook resident (public comment) [52:56]

> *“There is no citizenship requirement in the proposed ordinance amendment. We are asking that to be a member, you reside within the city of Westbrook.”*

— City Administrator Angela Holmes [53:19]

Boston pressed further — “So an illegal immigrant can be on this board then” — and Holmes repeated that the ordinance does not address immigration status, only residency. No council member weighed in on the exchange; the committee moved directly to its final vote afterward.

Referral to City Council
Moved by Councilor Chau, seconded by Vice President Shaughnessy, to refer the ordinance review as amended to City Council.

Key Decisions
✓ Approved 6–0 by roll call [55:16] (McCambridge, Shaughnessy, Munro, Chau, Faulkingham, Rairdon). Chair Rairdon noted one more board/committee ordinance review (Public Safety Committee) remains in this city-wide process.

Action Items
• Bring the Recreation & Conservation Commission ordinance rewrite to City Council for a vote — Assignee: City Council | Deadline: next scheduled meeting (occurred Oct. 19, 2026 as Order 2026-116).

Closing & Adjournment

Closing Remarks & Adjournment [57:32]

Discussion Summary
A councilor and Mayor Morse both thanked staff and committee/commission members for their time on this city-wide ordinance review process, with the Mayor noting the volunteer effort involved beyond city staff.

Key Decisions
✓ Adjourned by unanimous roll call, 6–0.

Action Items
None.

How this was made
This summary was produced from the meeting video (linked above, hosted on the City's Vimeo showcase). The audio was downloaded with Downie 4 and transcribed with speaker diarization using MacWhisper. Claude (Anthropic's AI) cross-checked names against the official city council roster, attributed speakers from context (introductions, roll-call order, direct address by the Chair) rather than the raw diarization labels alone, and drafted this summary and the quoted excerpts. Quotes are lightly cleaned of filler words/false starts but not reworded. Review tier: Not reviewed.

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